AT FIRST GLANCE, IT LOOKS LIKE another case against an international crime syndicate. But, for India, it is much bigger than that. A sweeping US investigation into 33-year-old jailed gangster, Lawrence Bishnoi, and his associates has not only exposed an alleged global criminal network but also changed the legal narrative around the 2023 killing of Khalistani separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar in Canada—one of the most contentious issues in New Delhi's recent ties with Ottawa.

The shift emerged with the US Department of Justice's (DoJ) July 7-8 announcement of Operation Hard Ball. Led by the Federal Bureau of Investigation in coordination with the Los Angeles Police Department, the Royal Canadian Mounted Police (RCMP) and European partners, the years-long investigation targeted three India-based transnational criminal syndicates, with the Lawrence Bishnoi Organised Crime Group at its centre (see *The US Indictment*). The participation of Canadian agencies reflected the cross-border nature of the probe.

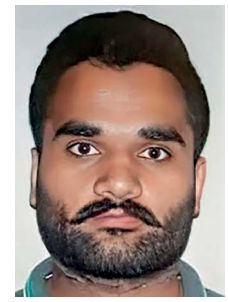
The operation accuses Bishnoi, fellow Canada-based gangster Goldy Brar and their associates of racketeering, extortion, drug trafficking, targeted killings, kidnappings, human smuggling and killing Nijjar outside a gurdwara in Surrey, British Columbia. Crucially, the indictment makes no allegations against the Indian government, its officials or intelligence agencies, reinforcing New Delhi's long-held position that the crime was the work of organised networks rather than the State. RCMP officials have also found no evidence linking Indian officials to the offences charged and acknowledged cooperation from Indian agencies. The development comes nearly three years after former Canadian prime minister Justin Trudeau said security agencies were investigating credible allegations of a "potential link" between Indian agents and Nijjar's murder. Separately, the US charged Bishnoi and Brar with orchestrating the killing.

According to US prosecutors, Bishnoi directed operations from an Indian prison using smuggled mobile phones and encrypted communications, while Brar managed North American operations and another associate, Rohit Godara, oversaw Europe. The syndicate allegedly recruited impoverished young men with promises of money, status and protection before sending them abroad, often on fraudulent visas. Investigators also accuse the network of extorting the Indian diaspora, exploiting high-profile threats, including against actor Salman Khan, to build notoriety.

THE US INDICTMENT

Op. Hard Ball targets three India-based crime syndicates

- **Thirty-seven defendants charged in three indictments targeting three India-based crime syndicates—the Lawrence Bishnoi Organised Crime Group, the Bhagwanpuria gang and the Dhanda network**
- **Arrests span the US, Canada and Spain with 24 suspects in custody, 10 still on the run**



- **Lawrence Bishnoi and Goldy Brar accused of running global criminal enterprises from India and abroad, and killing Khalistani separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar**
- **Nearly 1,000 kg of cocaine, 1 kg of heroin, cash and firearms seized during the operation**

The other two syndicates charged were the Bhagwanpuria gang, accused of murder-for-hire, drug trafficking and corruption, and the Dhanda network, which allegedly smuggled bulk cocaine and methamphetamine between the US and Canada.

A CALCULATED SHIFT

In late 2024, the DoJ indicted former Research and Analysis Wing (RAW) official Vikash Yadav and aide Nikhil Gupta over an alleged plot to kill Khalistani separatist Gurpatwant Singh Pannun in New York in June 2023. That charge also pointed to a possible link with Nijjar's killing.

The latest DoJ indictment, however, takes a different approach. "This is a strategic recalibration," says a senior Indian security official. "By treating the case as one of organised crime rather than State-directed action, it reduces diplomatic friction. But Washington has not exonerated Yadav or Gupta. It is unlikely to give up that leverage over India." An intelligence official says Bishnoi and Brar have become the main focus of legal and political scrutiny, reducing pressure on wider intelligence ties. Bishnoi, he adds, developed an independent motive to target Pannun, blending nationalist messaging with criminal power to expand his influence.

According to a key Indian security official, the contrasting legal approaches stemmed from the evidence available in the two cases. In the Pannun case, the DoJ considered the encrypted messages, financial trail and physical evidence sufficient to prosecute it as a state-linked murder-for-hire conspiracy. The Nijjar case posed a different evidentiary challenge. Early allegations relied heavily on signals intelligence, which is difficult to present in open court without exposing sensitive intelligence methods. By contrast, the Bishnoi network probe yielded conventional criminal evidence—communications, financial records and operational links—allowing prosecutors